

normal transmission is the “Byzantine” text-type. In every age, including the second and third centuries, it has been the traditional text.¹

So then, I claim that the NT text had a normal transmission, namely the fully predictable spread and reproduction of reliable copies of the Autographs from the earliest period down through the history of transmission until the availability of printed texts brought copying by hand to an end.

*The abnormal transmission*²

Turning now to the abnormal transmission, it no doubt commenced right along with the normal. The apostolic writings themselves contain strong complaints and warning against heretical and malicious activity. As Christianity spread and began to make an impact on the world, not everyone accepted it as ‘good news’. Opposition of various sorts arose. Also, there came to be divisions within the larger Christian community—in the NT itself notice is taken of the beginnings of some of these tangents. In some cases faithfulness to an ideological (theological) position evidently became more important than faithfulness to the NT Text. Certain it is that Church Fathers who wrote during the second century complained bitterly about the deliberate alterations to the Text perpetrated by ‘heretics’. Large sections of the extant writings of the early Fathers are precisely and exclusively concerned with combating the heretics. It is clear that during the second century, and possibly already in the first, such persons produced many copies of NT writings incorporating their alterations.³ Some apparently were quite widely circulated, for a time. The result was a welter of variant readings, to confuse the uninformed and mislead the unwary. Such a scenario was totally predictable. If the NT is in fact God’s Word

¹ Within the broad Byzantine stream there are dozens of rivulets (recall that F. Wisse isolated 36 groups, which included 70 subgroups), but the largest distinct line of transmission is Family 35, the main stream, and it was specifically this family that God used to preserve the precise original wording. For more on this please see Part II.

² I have been accused of inconsistency in that I criticize W-H for treating the NT like any other book and yet myself claim a “normal transmission” for the Majority Text. Not at all; I am referring to a normal transmission of an inspired Text, which W-H denied. I refer to believers copying a text that **they** believed to be inspired. Further, I also recognize an ‘abnormal transmission’, whereas W-H did not. Fee seriously distorts my position by ignoring my discussion of the abnormal transmission (G.D. Fee, “A Critique of W.N. Pickering’s *The Identity of the New testament Text: A Review Article*”, *The Westminster Theological Journal*, XLI [Spring, 1979], pp. 404-08) and misstating my view of the normal transmission (*Ibid.*, p. 399). I hold that 95% of the variants, the obvious transcriptional errors, belong (for the most part) to the normal transmission, whereas most of the remaining 5%, the ‘significant’ variants, belong to the abnormal transmission.

³ J.W. Burgon, *The Revision Revised* (London: John Murray, 1883), pp. 323-24.